The French Revolution

1789-1799 | From absolute monarchy to republic

Guiding question: How did France move from absolute monarchy to a republic?

Overview: In 1789, the old order came under pressure. Financial crisis, social inequality, food shortages and Enlightenment ideas sparked political upheaval, war and violence. In 1799, Napoleon seized power.

France before 1789

- Absolute monarchy: Louis XVI is king; political power is concentrated in the monarchy.
- Three Estates: society is divided into clergy, nobility and the Third Estate, with unequal rights and burdens.
- Financial crisis: war debts and royal spending strain the state; privileged groups resist tax reform.
- Food crisis: poor harvests in 1788 make bread scarce and expensive; unrest grows.

The three Estates

1st Estate	**Clergy**	Church officials; enjoy legal and tax privileges
2nd Estate	**Nobility**	Noble families; many traditional privileges
3rd Estate	**Commoners**	Bourgeoisie, workers and peasants; the vast majority

Remember: The Third Estate was socially diverse, but its members carried many taxes and dues.

Why did the crisis escalate?

Inequality | State debt | Bread prices | Enlightenment

Enlightenment ideas - liberty, equality and popular sovereignty - challenged the old order.

1789: The Revolution begins

5 May	The Estates-General meets. The key dispute: should votes be counted by Estate or by head (one vote per deputy)?
17 June	The Third Estate declares itself the National Assembly.
20 June	At the Tennis Court Oath, deputies pledge not to separate until France has a constitution.
14 July	The Bastille is stormed in Paris - a symbol of resistance to royal authority.
4 August	The National Assembly abolishes feudal privileges through the August Decrees.
26 August	The Declaration of the Rights of Man and of the Citizen proclaims liberty, legal equality, property and national sovereignty.

Remember: the monarchy does not end in 1789. A constitution is adopted in 1791, and the king remains in office for a time.

From king to republic

The Revolution becomes more radical - and ends with Napoleon’s coup.

1790-1792: The monarchy falls

5-6 Oct 1789	After a march on Versailles, the king and his family are brought to Paris.
1791	A constitution creates a constitutional monarchy. The king remains, but his powers are limited.
20-21 Jun 1791	The king’s attempted escape is stopped at Varennes. Trust in Louis XVI collapses further.
Apr 1792	France declares war on Austria; Prussia joins the conflict.
10 Aug 1792	The Tuileries Palace is stormed; the monarchy is suspended.
21 Sep 1792	The National Convention abolishes the monarchy and proclaims the Republic.

Do not confuse these dates

1791	Monarchy with a constitution
1792	Republic - no king
1799	Napoleon seizes power

Key point: a constitutional monarchy is not a republic. In 1791, France still has a king.

1793-1794: The Reign of Terror

- 21 January 1793: Louis XVI is executed. France is at war, while uprisings and internal conflicts spread.
- The Committee of Public Safety gains emergency powers. Maximilien Robespierre becomes one of its leading figures.
- During the Reign of Terror, suspected enemies of the Revolution are prosecuted; many are executed.
- 27-28 July 1794: Robespierre is overthrown and executed. The Terror subsides.

1795-1799: The Directory

The Constitution of 1795 establishes a five-member Directory as the executive government.

The regime remains unstable amid war, economic problems and political struggles.

9 November 1799: Napoleon’s coup overthrows the Directory. This is commonly treated as the end of the Revolution.

Consequences

- Feudal privileges and the old legal Estates system are dismantled.
- Equality before the law becomes a central principle.
- Women remain excluded from equal political rights.
- Revolutionary ideas reshape France and influence Europe.

Key terms to know

Ancien Régime
the old order before 1789

National Assembly
body seeking a constitution

National sovereignty
authority comes from the nation

Constitutional monarchy
a king bound by a constitution

Coup d’état
seizure of power outside normal rules

In brief: inequality + crisis -> Revolution -> Republic -> Terror -> Directory -> Napoleon.